

slumped in easy chairs in their homes, staring blankly at the vulgar banalities that flash across the screens of their television sets.

I've found that a disheartening number of businessmen and executives— young and old—obstinately maintain that

"business and culture don't mix." They cling to the notion that businessmen have neither the temperament nor the

169

patience to understand and appreciate anything "artistic."

They seem to fear that participation in cultural activities would somehow "soften" them and make them less able to cope with the harsh realities of the business world. Without doubt, these are the weakest and most fallacious of all arguments.

The world's most successful commercial and industrial leaders have always been noted as patrons of the arts and active supporters of all cultural activities. There are also innumerable proofs that commercial and industrial development, far from being incompatible with cultural progress, actually gives culture its strongest forward impetus. It can be shown that the arts have always flourished most vigorously in prosperous, highly commercialized and industrialized nations.

One excellent example of this is provided by the Republic of Venice, which dominated the commerce of Europe and Asia for nearly eight centuries. The Venetian traders were as shrewd and as materialistic as any the world has ever known.

The Venetians were also crack industrialists, mastering production-line techniques more than six hundred years before the first assembly line made its appearance in the United States. The gigantic arsenal at Venice was geared to turn out at least one fully equipped, seagoing ship a day on an assembly line that began with the laying of the vessel's keel and finished with the arming and provisioning of the ship.